Let's look at how these techniques tie into RSpec's configuration system. Inside a configure block, you can use the following methods to specify which specs to run:

config.example_status_persistence_file_path = 'spec/examples.txt'

Tells RSpec where to store the passed, failed, or pending status of each example between runs, enabling the --only-failures and --next-failure options.

config.filter_run_excluding :specific_to_some_os

Excludes examples from being run; useful for permanent exclusions based on environmental factors like OS, Ruby version, or an environment variable.

config.filter_run_when_matching :some_metadata

Sets a *conditional* filter that only applies when there are matching examples; this is how, for instance, RSpec runs just the examples you've tagged with the :focus metadata.

Metadata

As we discussed in *Slicing and Dicing Specs with Metadata*, RSpec's metadata system makes it possible for you to categorize your specs in a way that makes sense to you. Metadata is deeply connected to the configuration system. Many of RSpec's configuration options we've discussed accept (or require) a metadata argument, which determines the examples or groups the config option applies to.

You can also *set* metadata using the configuration system. The following methods let you write metadata on examples or groups:

config.define_derived_metadata(file_path: /unit/) { |meta| meta[:type] = :unit }

Derives one metadata value from another. Here, we tag all the specs in the unit directory with type: :unit. If we had left out the file_path argument, this call would have set metadata for *all* examples.

config.alias_example_to :alias_for_it, some_metadata: :value

Defines an alternative to the built-in it method that creates an example *and* attaches metadata. This is how RSpec's built-in fit method marks examples you want to focus on.

config.alias_example_group_to :alias_for_describe, some_metadata: :value

Like the previous alias, except that it works on example groups instead of individual examples (like RSpec's fdescribe).